

We already knew slurs were pernicious. Now we know why.

An experimental study of adnominal and predicative uses of slurs

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1. BACKGROUND

The Literature on Slurs

The *How* Question

How do slurs encode their pejorative meaning?

Truth-conditional meaning, conventional implicature, presupposition, etc.

The *What* Question

What kind of pejorative content do slurs convey?

The speaker's contemptuous feelings, negative judgments of the target class, etc.

The Pejorative Content of Slurs

Since there is little research about the *What Question*, we started with formulating three very simplified options as to how to interpret slurs.

They roughly correspond to proposals and observations that have been developed in the philosophical and linguistic literature, but they do not mean to be exhaustive.

Three options: the pejorative content of a slur...

Agent-Oriented

...reflects the negative attitudes of some salient agent (typically the speaker)

Intersubjective

...reflects the negative attitudes of not only the speaker/agent but further conversational participants, or even a larger linguistic community

Target-Oriented

... brings to salience the negative properties of the derogated person(s)

Three options for Expressive Content

Note also that these three options mirror the interpretations of insults like 'jerk' that we tested in Domaneschi, Cepollaro and Stojanovic (2024).

'X is jerk':

Agent-Oriented: the agent dislikes X (the target)

Intersubjective: the agent and the other people in the context dislike the target

Target-Oriented: the target is bad (in some relevant way)

The agent-oriented interpretation

The pejorative content encoded in the meaning of a slur reflects the negative attitudes of some salient agent (typically the speaker)

This is the most wide-spread view about expressives in general, including particularistic insults like *jerk*

(Potts 2005, Schlenker 2007)

This interpretation corresponds to the intuition that when people use slurs, this is more telling about themselves than about their targets

(Nunberg 2018)

Complicity

... is the idea that what slurs communicate seems to go beyond how the speaker feels about the target (hence a problem for the agent-oriented interpretation).

E.g., Croom (2011) and Camp (2013) talk about the unwelcome complicity that non-bigoted participants to a conversation feel when someone uses a slur - as if the speaker were not merely expressing how they feel, but imposing a certain view of the target.

Under the target-oriented interpretation, the speaker says something negative about the target, rather than merely express negative feelings. Hence if the audience doesn't challenge the speaker, the negative attribution becomes part of the common ground (Stalnaker 2002)

Our Research Question

How should we understand the pejorative content that slurs convey when they occur in predicative (X is *S*) and adnominal (that *S* X is Y) positions?

To start investigating this question, we looked at 3rd person uses in *predicative* and *adnominal* positions, and we canvassed for participants' intuitions about the best way to understand **what is meant** by a sentence.

Dan says: 'That frog Isidora has arrived'. What does he communicate?

That Isidora has arrived, that Isidora is French, and that...

...*he* doesn't like French people? (Agent-oriented)

...*he and other people* don't like French people? (Intersubjective)

...*Isidora* is despicable (for being French)? (Target-oriented)

2. OUR EXPERIMENT

Method and Design

Participants 120 native Italian speakers [MA= 31.42; SD=14.55; 67f; 48m; 5other]

Items 8 vignettes

CONTEXT	TARGET
Luca says to Chiara:	ITALIAN SLURS frocio (targeting gay men, m.) terrone (targeting Southern people, m.) polentona (targeting Northern people, f.) cicciona (targeting overweight people, f.) crucco (targeting German people, m.) sbirro (targeting police officers, m) negro (targeting Black people, m.) zingaro (targeting Roma people, m.). <i>Frequency + Offensiveness</i> (Sulpizio et al. 2020)

Method and Design

Task Selection task: three options

CONTEXT	TARGET	What does Luca mean?	
Luca says to Chiara:	AD-NOMINAL That faggot Marco is drinking a coffee	AO	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he despises homosexuals
	PREDICATIVE Marco is [a] faggot	INTER SBJ 1	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he, like many others, despises homosexuals
		TO	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and homosexuals are despicable

Method and Design

Fillers 18 fillers

CONTEXT	TARGET
Luca says to Chiara:	PREDICATIVE Marco is a liar

NEGATIVE PREDICATES (Tr. Engl)
liar / rude / impolite / unreliable / lazy / uncouth / nosy / cruel / unfair / bad

What does Luca mean?

AO	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he despises homosexuals	☐
INTER SBJ 1	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he, like many others, despises homosexuals	☐
TO	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and homosexuals are despicable	☐

Method and Design

Fillers 18 fillers

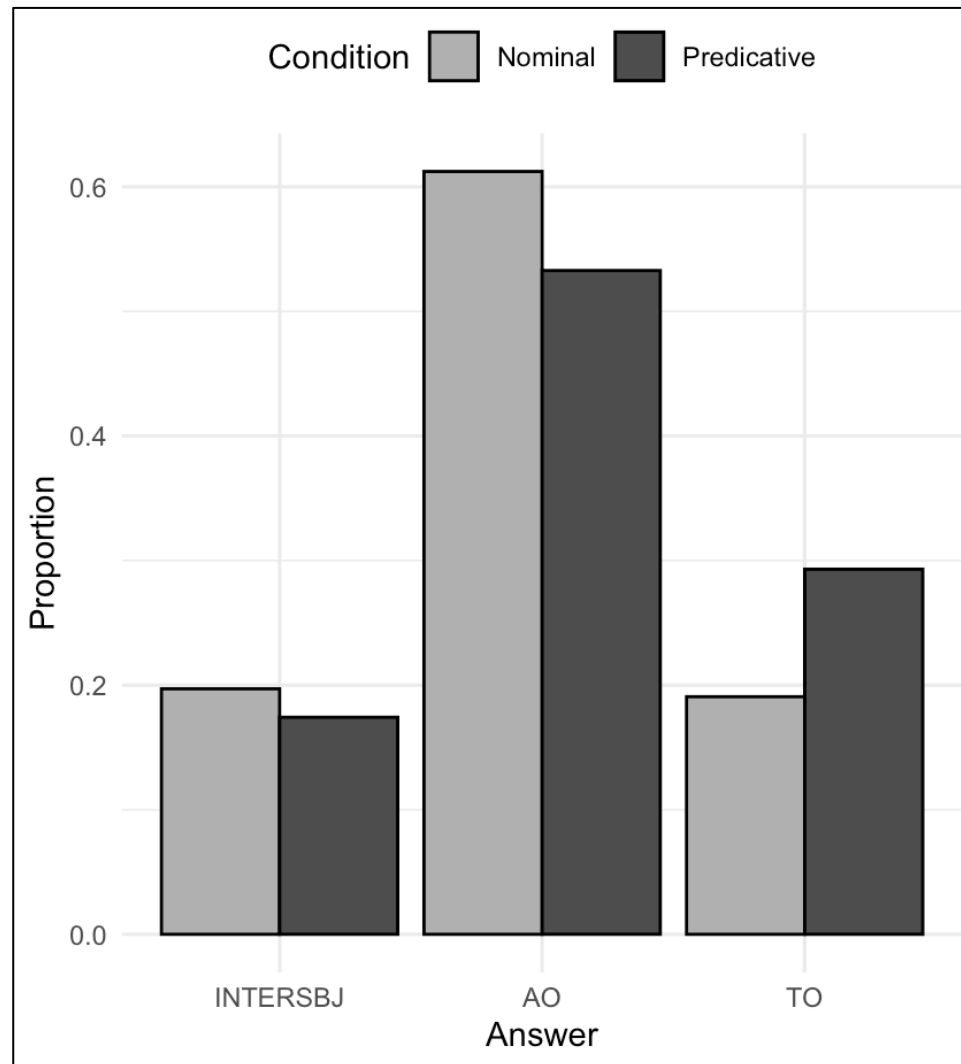
CONTEXT	TARGET
Luca says to Chiara:	PREDICATIVE Marco is adorable

POSITIVE PREDICATES (Tr. Engl)
Kind / intelligent / wise / generous / reliable / adorable / patient / brilliant / discreetly

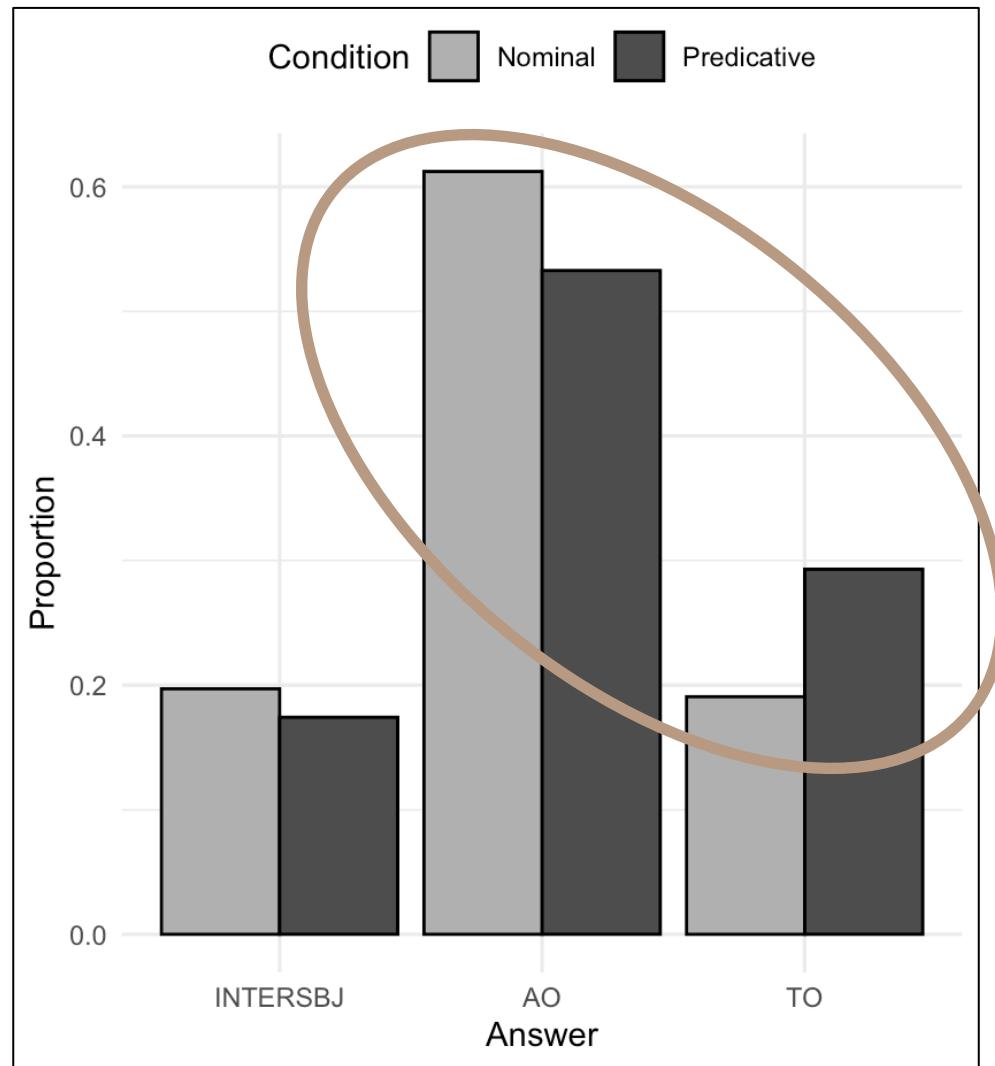
What does Luca mean?

AO	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he despises homosexuals	☐
INTER SBJ 1	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he, like many others, despises homosexuals	☐
TO	That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and homosexuals are despicable	☐

Results



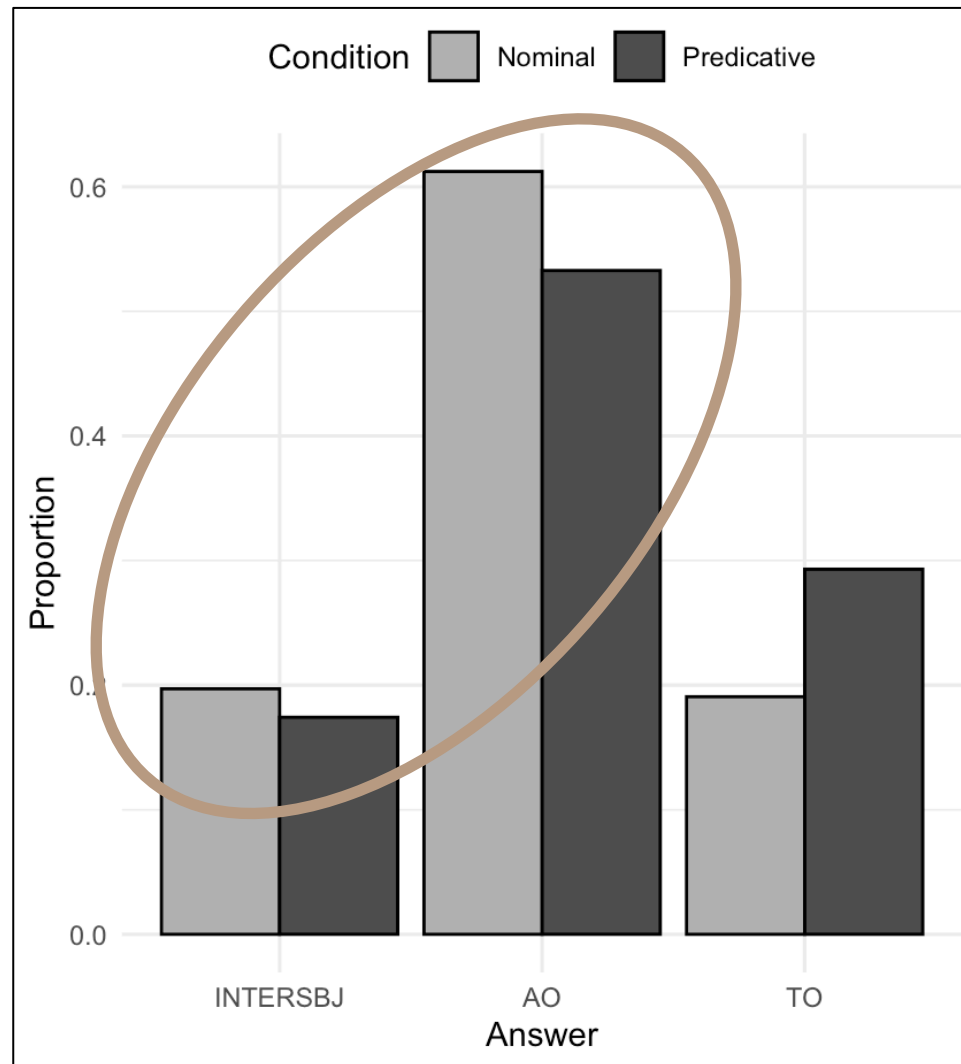
Results



Pearson's χ^2

$\chi^2(2, N = 960) = 13.684, p = 0.001$

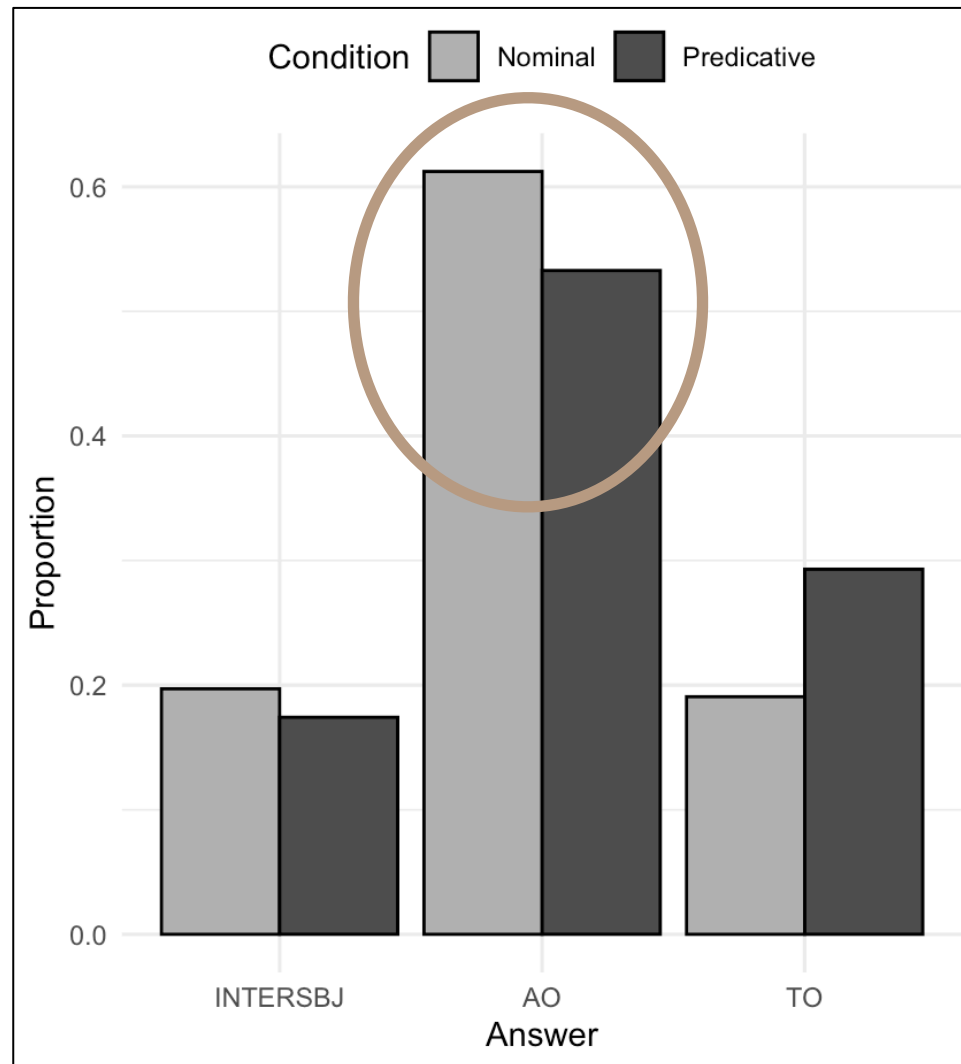
Results



Pearson's χ^2

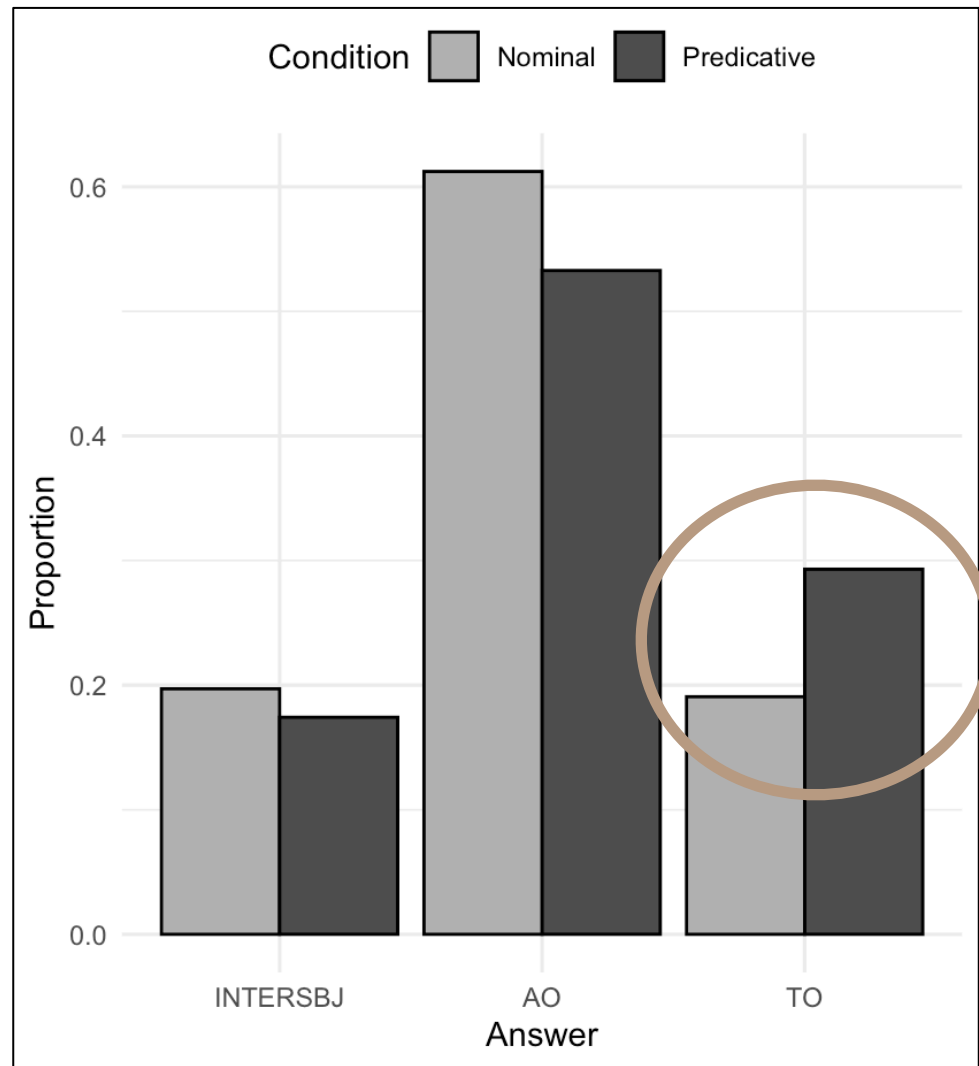
$\chi^2(2, N = 960) = 13.684, p = 0.001$

Results



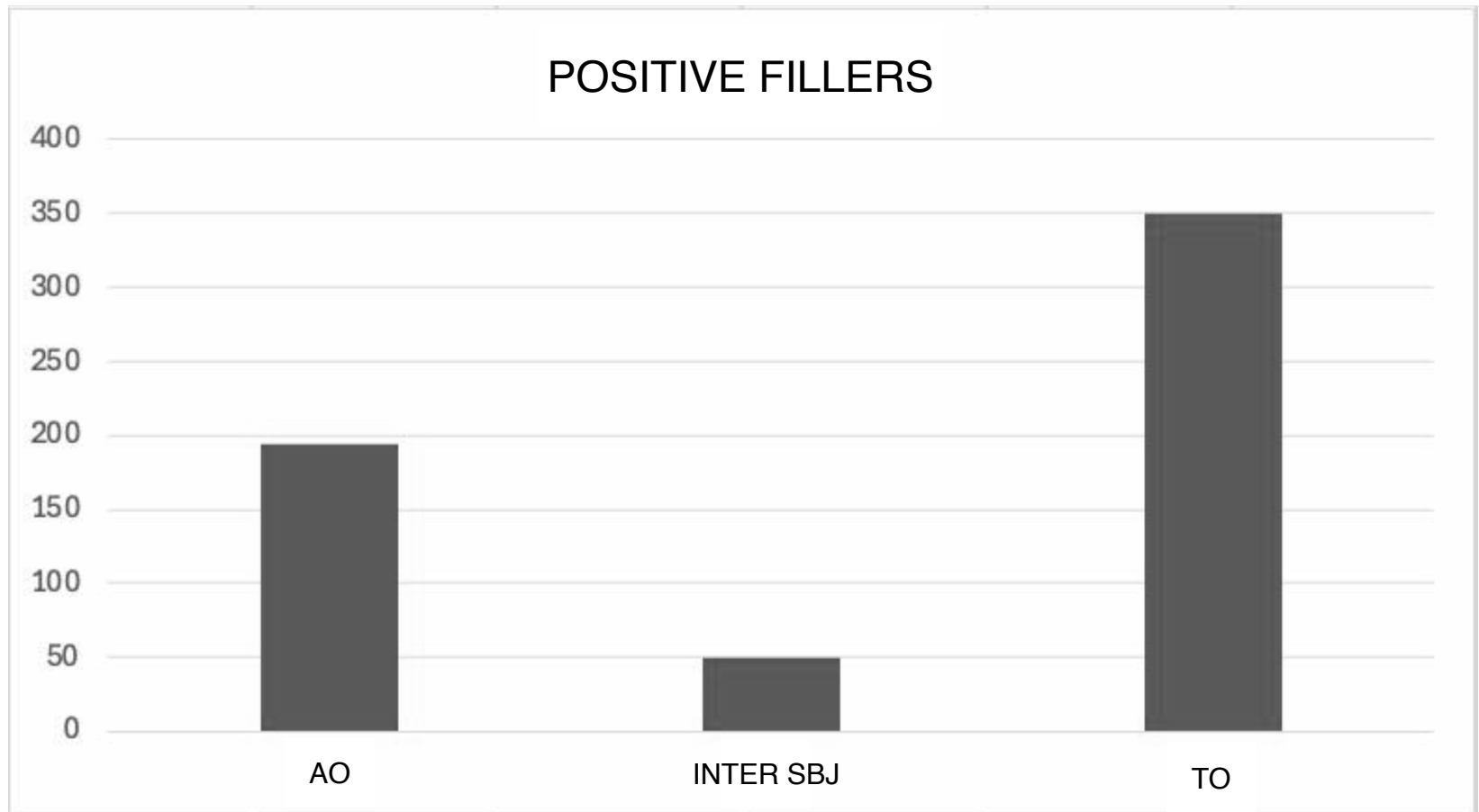
AO ($Z = 2.48, p = 0.01$)

Results

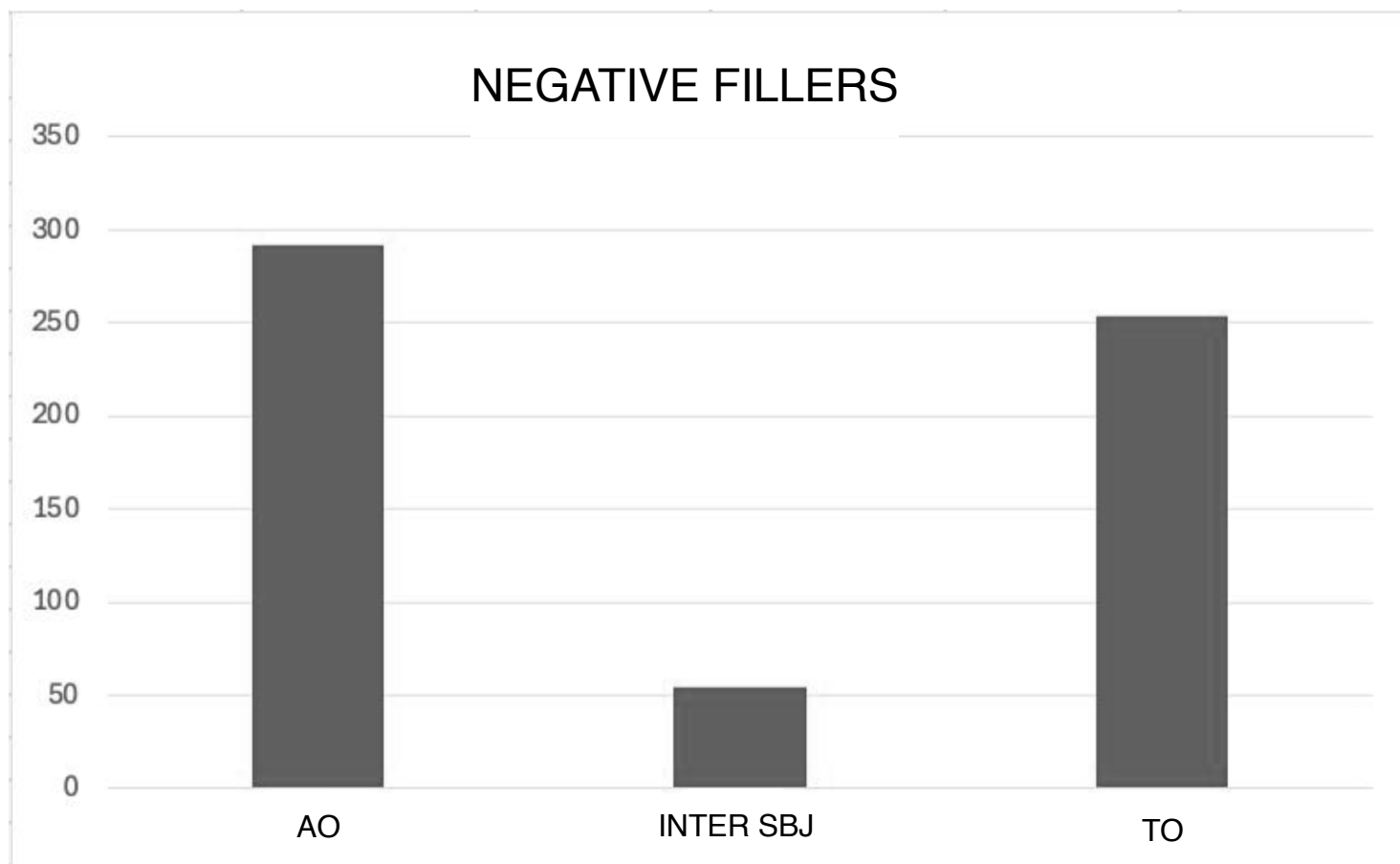


TO ($Z = -3.69$, $p < .001$)

Results: Fillers



Results: Fillers



3. DISCUSSION

The Literature on Slurs

The *How* Question

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The *What* Question

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Three options: slurs' pejorative content...

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Target-Oriented

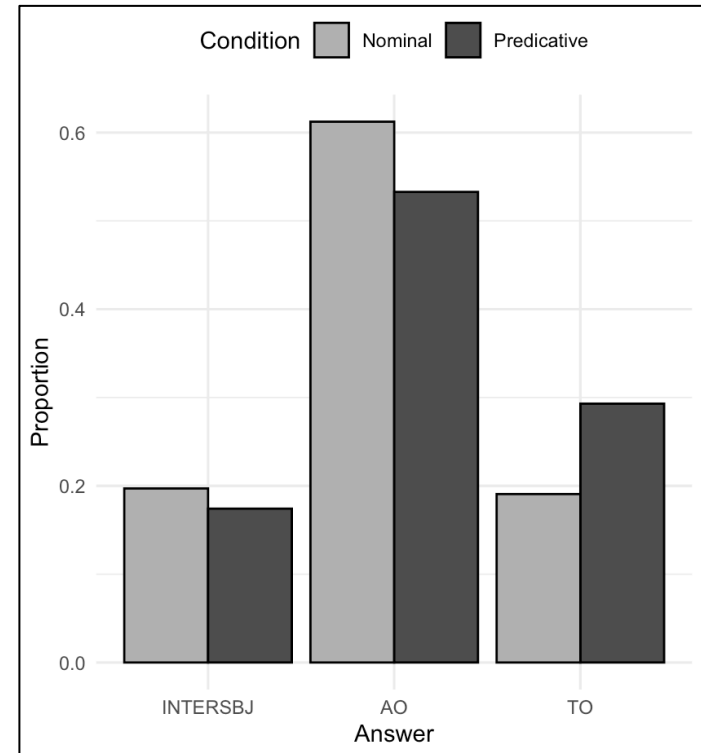
... brings to salience the negative properties of the derogated one(s)

The *What* Question

The agent-oriented interpretation is strongly preferred for all uses of slurs.

Does this mean that the content encoded by slurs is agent-oriented?

Not necessarily. For one, the target-oriented and the intersubjective interpretations also received some attention, albeit to a lesser extent.



Important observation

It is quite possible that some participants refrained from selecting the TO interpretation in order avoid any involvement in the discriminatory perspective. They may have wanted to restrain from instances of hate speech such as 'gays are despicable', even if it clearly occurs under the heading of 'what Luca means'

What does Luca mean?

AO

That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he despises homosexuals

INTER
SBJ

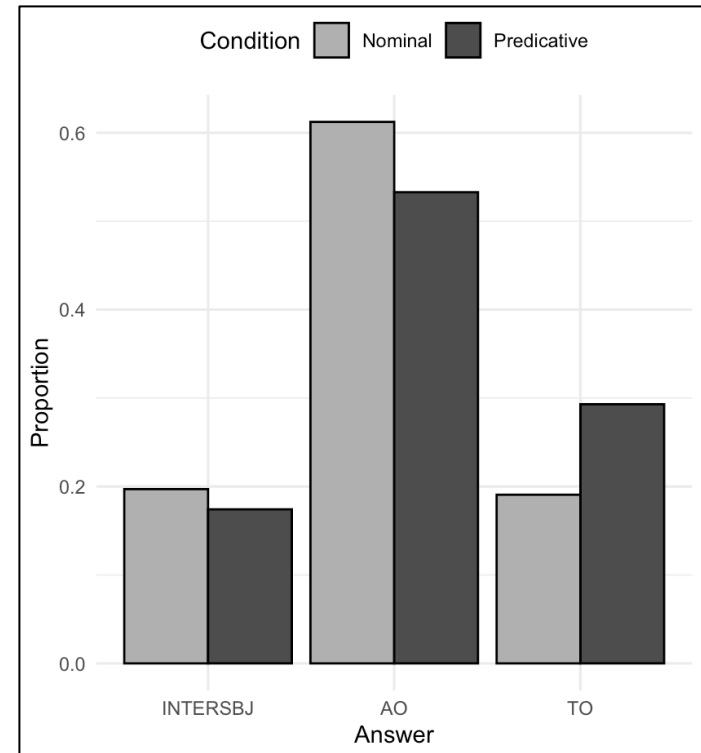
That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and he, like many others, despises homosexuals

TO

That Marco is drinking a coffee, that Marco is homosexual and homosexuals are despicable

Target-orientedness correlates with At-issue-ness

The target-oriented interpretation receives higher scores in predicative (X is an S) rather than adnominal constructions (That S X has arrived). Adnominal content is presuppositional, while predicative content is at issue. If the target's membership in the group is already in the common ground, then it would be odd for the speaker to lay out his own attitudes as being at issue.

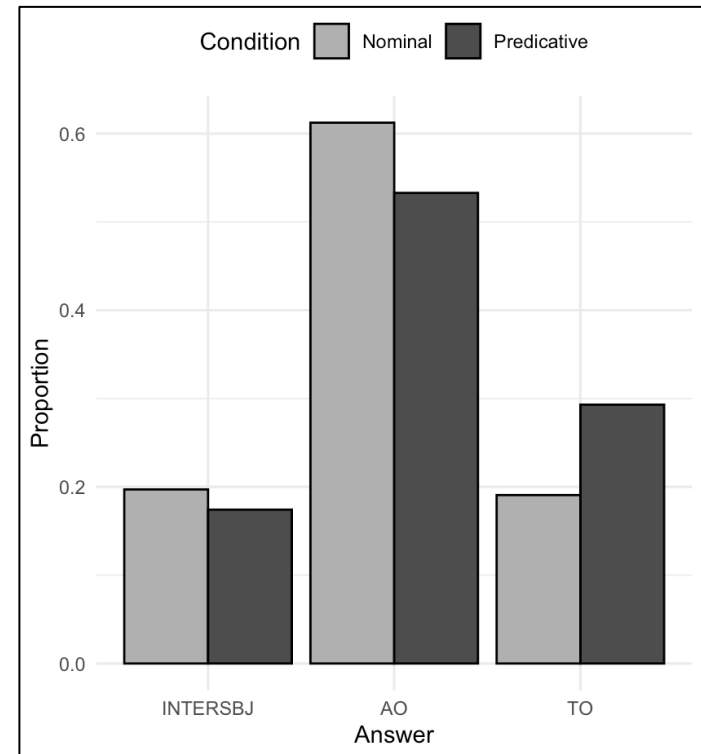


Complicity revisited

If we take the results at face value, and go for the agent-oriented interpretation, there are (at least) two ways to address complicity:

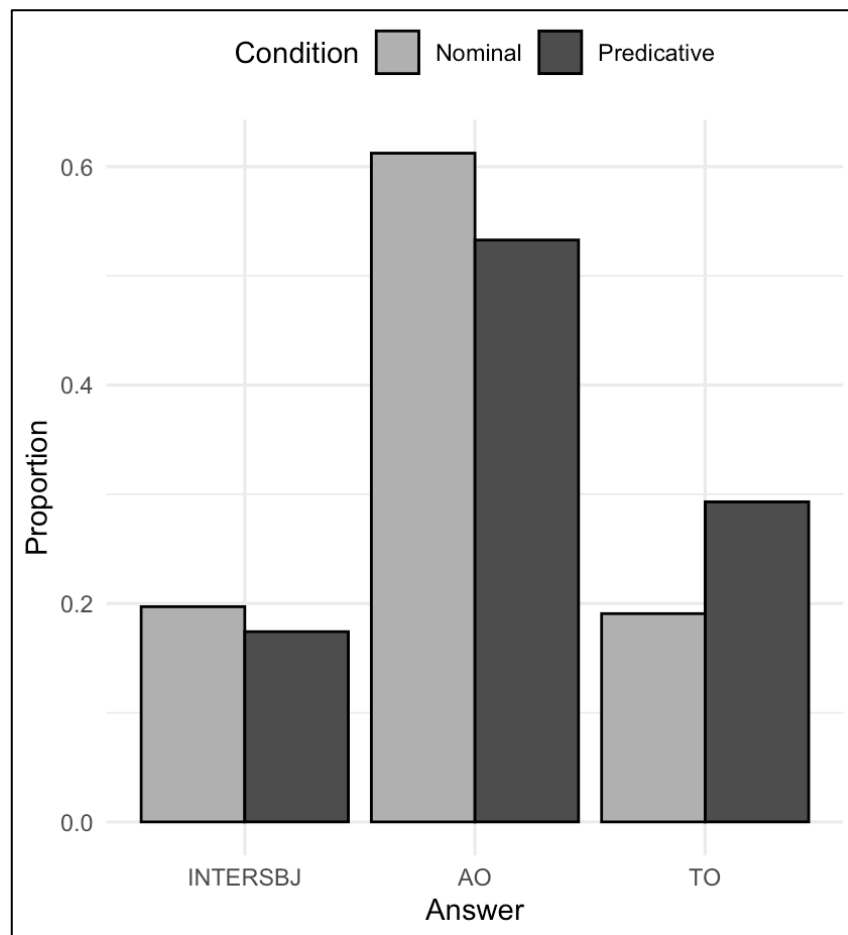
(1) question the assumption that if it's about the speaker's attitudes, we don't feel "involved".

(2) invoke Dan López de Sa (2008)'s presuppositions of commonality.



How reliable are folk intuitions?

Alternatively, we can hold onto a target-oriented theoretical account (as in Cepollaro & Stojanovic 2016), since speakers don't necessarily have access to semantic content. The upshot of this is that speakers will allow the target-oriented derogatory content slip easily into the common ground, and **that makes slurs bloody pernicious.**



Thanks